

Liturgy for Technology: A Reflection on Designing for Conquest or Liberation

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ABSTRACT

One way in which contemporary churches and tech companies parallel each other is their earnest belief that they can make the world a better place while making eschatological, or ideological, claims. While they do not necessarily have the same ideas of what that future world would look like, they both build their collective faith through sacred artifacts and rituals, widespread evangelism, and real-world praxis. This piece juxtaposes excerpts from both theological and technological traditions organized in a liturgy, or the order of worship, for a Sunday church service. The service starts by highlighting how the remaking and rebuilding espoused by these traditions could reinforce hegemonic values such as settler colonialism and white supremacy. However, the selections then shift to highlight examples of resilience and liberation that also emerge from both. We hope to provide a space for those who build and research technology to contemplate their roles in either designing towards conquest or liberation.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**; • **Social and professional topics** → **Professional topics**.

KEYWORDS

technosolutionism, decoloniality, liberation theology, worship service

ACM Reference Format:

Joy Ming and SueAnn Shiah. 2024. Liturgy for Technology: A Reflection on Designing for Conquest or Liberation. In *Extended Abstracts of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI EA '24)*, May 11–16, 2024, Honolulu, HI, USA. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 8 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3613905.3644061>

AUTHORS' NOTE

We, the authors, met through the Progressive Asian American Christians, an online community for socially, politically, and theologically progressive Asian American and Asian diaspora Christians to support each other and discuss faith, identity, and current events [1]. As part of tech and church cultures, we found ourselves faced with similar concerns in both spaces. We saw how the ideologies of both

of these institutions marginalized communities, treated them as less than—queer people have been barred from attending church and the digital divide kept poorer users from accessing tech. We also questioned our own complicity in this pattern of oppression and how we might be able to shift power to break it. We then found ourselves turning to similar answers of what resistance looks like—stories about how communities have fought to have their voices heard, lessons in how builders reshaped spaces to account for these voices, and frameworks like liberation theology and design justice for how to prevent this from happening again. We present some of these sources that have influenced our journey in order to bring others along—especially those designing, building, and using technology who may not yet be thinking about these types of questions.

This piece is written for an audience of predominantly wealthy, male, White and East Asian, Christian-adjacent, United States-centric tech workers and researchers with the hopes that it could one day be shared with congregations in Silicon Valley and other tech-adjacent Christian groups. We hope to speak to this audience as we share some of these identities, but also to lift up the voices of the activists, theologians, and scholars who do not. We use the format of a Christian liturgy not only because it may be familiar to some of our audience, but also because the liturgical format itself is based in collective reflection and criticality through public action [6]—specifically with regards to technology. We note that this piece is fairly experimental and may be challenging in different ways. In order to account for folks who are unfamiliar with the liturgy format or are jarred by the juxtaposition of tech and church cultures, we encourage the audience to reflect on any points of conflict. However, beyond reflection, we also note that institutional churches have a mixed history of not only contemplation, but also harm for individuals and communities. We hope that we all keep this in mind and that those with religious trauma carefully consider how they would like to engage.

This piece is set up like a Protestant church service, inspired by previous services from various denominations, including Presbyterian, Lutheran, Methodist, and Episcopalian. The *italicized text* describes the components of the service and gives context for the selection of the excerpts. The plain text (i.e., without italics or bold) is meant to be spoken by the leader of the service and the **bold text** by the assembly (i.e., all those who are gathered—including you!). There are also sections that are marked with a * that indicates that everyone is invited to stand as they are able to encourage a more embodied experience.

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CHI EA '24, May 11–16, 2024, Honolulu, HI, USA
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ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-0331-7/24/05
<https://doi.org/10.1145/3613905.3644061>

1 OPENING

1.1 Prelude

The prelude is often played as an opening as worshippers enter the service. This is an opportunity for quiet reflection and sets the tone for the service. The selection for this section is “Jerusalem,” by Sir Hubert Parry in 1916 (Sample Setting). This hymn builds on a patriotic poem by William Blake has been referred to as England’s “unofficial anthem.” As you are listening to this hymn, pay attention to the imagery it evokes of colonial conquer.

And did those feet in ancient time
Walk upon England’s mountain green?
And was the holy Lamb of God
On England’s pleasant pastures seen?
And did the countenance divine
Shine forth upon our clouded hills?
And was Jerusalem builded here
Among those dark satanic mills?

Bring me my bow of burning gold!
Bring me my arrows of desire!
Bring me my spear! O clouds, unfold!
Bring me my chariot of fire!
I will not cease from mental fight,
Nor shall my sword sleep in my hand,
Till we have built Jerusalem
In England’s green and pleasant land.

1.2 Word of Welcome

Welcome to all those who are gathered here! You are invited to join today’s service as you are and participate in as much as you would like. Today’s central question is: Are we designing towards conquest or liberation? Collectively, we will reflect on our roles as designers, builders, and researchers of technology. This service is set up as a series of references from both church and tech cultures. As we proceed, consider how these different excerpts challenge or affirm what you believe or is held true in your contexts. Think about where and what you feel in your body. In the back of your bulletin (Appendix A), we have included a reflection tool you can use to keep track of your journey.

Please stand as you are able to join us in our call to worship.

1.3 *Call to Worship

*This portion of the service sets the tone for the rest of the service. It is often done as a call and response, where the leader starts a thought (in plain text) and the assembly finishes it (in **bold text**). We assign the assembly common wisdoms in tech culture, mirroring how these maxims of efficiency and innovation are repeated often and become key tenets in how technology is designed and created.*

As creators and builders of our futures, of our Jerusalems—
Help us to bring light into the darkness.

Remind us that we just have to have faith,
That we have to “trust the process”
Because “if we build it, they will come.”

And forgive us as we err along the way,
As we “move fast and break things”
In the service of a better world.

Help us to turn from temptation,
To center the users, the target markets—
To make sure we “don’t be evil.”

Let us remember these tenets our leaders have bestowed upon us
As we build a better world, together.
Amen.

1.4 *Hymn of Praise

Usually the hymns are from a traditional collection based on the denomination of the church. However, we are adding to this collection by including the output of ChatGPT when given the prompt “write a hymn to technology,” which we generated specifically for this liturgy. In this hymn we see not only imagery of “circuits, code” but also of the ways technology has “touched our lives in countless ways” throughout society.

(Verse) Oh, technology, our guiding light,
In the modern world, you shine so bright,
With circuits, code, and innovation’s grace,
You’ve brought us to a boundless space.

(Chorus) Hail, technology, our muse and guide,
In you, our dreams and hopes collide,
You’ve touched our lives in countless ways,
We sing your praises with grateful praise.

(Verse) With silicon minds and fiber’s grace,
You’ve made the world a smaller place,
From wired waves to wireless skies,
You’ve opened up our eager eyes. (Chorus)

(Verse) In medical labs and factories grand,
You’ve lent a helping, robotic hand,
In pixels and bits, we find our voice,
With you, we make a conscious choice. (Chorus)

(Verse) So let us celebrate your art,
The fusion of science and human heart,
In circuits and screens, we find our way,
Hail, technology, our guiding ray. (Chorus)

2 READINGS

2.1 First Lesson

A Christian church service often grounds its lessons in excerpts from the Bible, the sacred text. However, we wanted to explore some lessons tech culture holds sacred as well. Our first reading comes from “Building Global Community,” written by Mark Zuckerberg in 2017. In this manifesto, he describes his vision for how Facebook can “help save the world” [30] by bringing people together.

On our journey to connect the world, we often discuss products we’re building and updates on our business. Today I want to focus on the most important question of all: are we building the world we all want? ...Our greatest opportunities are now global – like spreading

prosperity and freedom, promoting peace and understanding, lifting people out of poverty, and accelerating science. Our greatest challenges also need global responses – like ending terrorism, fighting climate change, and preventing pandemics. Progress now requires humanity coming together not just as cities or nations, but also as a global community.

This is especially important right now. Facebook stands for bringing us closer together and building a global community. When we began, this idea was not controversial. Every year, the world got more connected and this was seen as a positive trend. Yet now, across the world there are people left behind by globalization, and movements for withdrawing from global connection. There are questions about whether we can make a global community that works for everyone, and whether the path ahead is to connect more or reverse course.

This is a time when many of us around the world are reflecting on how we can have the most positive impact. I am reminded of my favorite saying about technology: “We always overestimate what we can do in two years, and we underestimate what we can do in ten years.” We may not have the power to create the world we want immediately, but we can all start working on the long term today. In times like these, the most important thing we at Facebook can do is develop the social infrastructure to give people the power to build a global community that works for all of us.

2.2 Psalm

The readings often include sacred verses or songs that evoke vivid imagery from the biblical Book of Psalms. Our psalm today comes from an excerpt of the spoken word piece “AI, Ain’t I A Woman” by Joy Buolamwini. In it, she highlights the way artificial intelligence can misinterpret the images of iconic black women. Usually, psalms are read responsively, but in this case, we would encourage highlighting the voice of the creator through this video presentation of the piece.

My heart smiles as I bask in their legacies
Knowing their lives have altered many destinies
In her eyes, I see my mother’s poise
In her face, I glimpse my auntie’s grace
In this case of déjà vu
A 19th century question comes into view
In a time, when Sojourner truth asked
“Ain’t I a woman?”

Today, we pose this question to new powers
Making bets on artificial intelligence, hope towers
The Amazonians peek through
Windows blocking Deep Blues
As Faces increment scars
Old burns, new urns
Collecting data chronicling our past
Often forgetting to deal with

Gender race and class,
Again, I ask
“Ain’t I a Woman?”

Face by face the answers seem uncertain
Young and old, proud icons are dismissed
Can machines ever see my queens as I view them?
Can machines ever see our grandmothers as we knew them?

2.3 Epistle Reading

Usually there is a reading from the Epistles (or letters) of Paul, thirteen books of the New Testament meant to guide early Christian churches in how they should operate. Our letter is from another author, Rev. Dr. Martin Luther King Jr., who was trying to guide the church of his time. In 1963, while he was imprisoned in the Birmingham jail as a participant in nonviolent demonstrations against segregation, he wrote the following response to a public statement issued by eight white religious leaders of the South. We also encourage the use of a recording of the author’s voice for this portion, such as this one.

Oppressed people cannot remain oppressed forever. The urge for freedom will eventually come. This is what has happened to the American Negro. Something within has reminded him of his birthright of freedom; something without has reminded him that he can gain it. ... But I have tried to say that this normal and healthy discontent can be channeled through the creative outlet of nonviolent direct action. Now this approach is being dismissed as extremist. I must admit that I was initially disappointed in being so categorized.

But as I continued to think about the matter, I gradually gained a bit of satisfaction from being considered an extremist. Was not Jesus an extremist in love? – “Love your enemies, bless them that curse you, pray for them that spitefully use you.” Was not Amos an extremist for justice? – “Let justice roll down like waters and righteousness like a mighty stream.” Was not Paul an extremist for the gospel of Jesus Christ? – “I bear in my body the marks of the Lord Jesus.” Was not Martin Luther an extremist? – “Here I stand; I can do no other so help me God.” ... So the question is not whether we will be extremist, but what kind of extremists we will be. Will we be extremists for hate, or will we be extremists for love? Will we be extremists for the preservation of injustice, or will we be extremists for the cause of justice?

I wish you had commended the Negro demonstrators of Birmingham for their sublime courage, their willingness to suffer, and their amazing discipline in the midst of the most inhuman provocation. One day the South will recognize its real heroes. ... One day the South will know that when these disinherited children of God sat down at lunch counters they were in reality standing up for the best in the American dream and the most sacred values in our Judeo-Christian heritage.

2.4 *Gospel Reading

The gospel is usually the culmination of the readings, featuring a teaching or revelation of Jesus Christ from the first four books of the New Testament. Our gospel reading comes from an essay from 2017 by Courtney Martin called “The Reductive Seduction Of Other People’s Problems.” In it, she challenges the notion of finding meaning from helping others, captured by what she refers to as “the patronizing, dangerously simple phrase ‘save the world.’”

Let’s pretend, for a moment, that you are a 22-year-old college student in Kampala, Uganda. You’re sitting in class and discreetly scrolling through Facebook on your phone. You see that there has been another mass shooting in America, this time in a place called San Bernardino. You’ve never heard of it. You’ve never been to America. But you’ve certainly heard a lot about gun violence in the U.S. It seems like a new mass shooting happens every week. You wonder if you could go there and get stricter gun legislation passed. You’d be a hero to the American people, a problem-solver, a lifesaver. How hard could it be? Maybe there’s a fellowship for high-minded people like you to go to America after college and train as social entrepreneurs. You could start the nonprofit organization that ends mass shootings, maybe even win a humanitarian award by the time you are 30.

Sound hopelessly naive? Maybe even a little deluded? It is. And yet, it’s not much different from how too many Americans think about social change in the “Global South.” ...

The “reductive seduction” is not malicious, but it can be reckless. For two reasons. First, it’s dangerous for the people whose problems you’ve mistakenly diagnosed as easily solvable. There is real fallout when well-intentioned people attempt to solve problems without acknowledging the underlying complexity. ... There’s a better way. For all of us. Resist the reductive seduction of other people’s problems and, instead, fall in love with the longer-term prospect of staying home and facing systemic complexity head on. Or go if you must, but stay long enough, listen hard enough so that “other people” become real people. But, be warned, they may not seem so easy to “save.” ...

Don’t go because you’ve fallen in love with solvability. Go because you’ve fallen in love with complexity. Don’t go because you want to do something virtuous. Go because you want to do something difficult. Don’t go because you want to talk. Go because you want to listen.

3 MESSAGE

3.1 Sermon

The sermon is usually the centerpiece of the Protestant worship service, where the leader synthesizes the material presented in the service, often in a way that relates to the day-to-day lives of the assembly. We wanted this sermon to strike a balance, using charismatic language

and concrete examples of current events mixed with academic references to the theories that underpin our contribution.

Even though technology and religion are seemingly at odds, their histories have been intertwined, with the technology of the printing press and online platforms as means of distributing religious material to the masses [19]. Carolyn Chen [7] describes a “Techtopia” where tech culture takes the place of organized religion—where denizens find their fulfilment in a utopian workplace that has borrowed the creeds and doctrines (i.e., mission statements), collective rituals (i.e., social activities), and actual practices (i.e., mindfulness meditation) of religion. At the center of all of this is the belief that technology, that this particular brand of venture-backed innovation will fix the world. That those who call themselves “technologists” are the ones who would do it. This mirrors the idea of Christians seeing themselves as God’s chosen people building a version of heaven on earth, or what Saint Augustine calls the “City of God” [27].

3.1.1 Building Patterns of Oppression. Unfortunately, this belief, and the attempts at building and reshaping our world that come with it, often reinforces and exacerbates systems of oppression. As technology itself often reflects the sociopolitical ecosystems in which it is built [32], technology that is built from people in centers of power, like Silicon Valley, often embed values of hubris and imperialism, simply because it is in the air their creators breathe, the water they swim in. This is reflected in the imagery ChatGPT evokes of the “distant land” and “wireless skies” (Section 1.4).

In Mark Zuckerberg’s manifesto, he exalts a globalization fueled by his technology and addresses the ills like poverty that afflict foreign lands—echoing the language used by the prelude (Section 1.1) of building a “green and pleasant land” that violently displaced “dark satanic mills.” This sentiment of presuming to know both what is best for others but also how it should be achieved is seen also in Silicon Valley maxims (like “move fast and break things”) embedded throughout the Call to Worship (Section 1.3), which has resulted in the spread of “digital colonialism” [16] that “propagate historical power relations and patterns of oppression” [28]. This hubris has real, devastating consequences. For example, the United Nations has highlighted Facebook’s role in spreading hate speech in Myanmar, contributing to the genocide of the Rohingya people [2]. Additionally, Joy Buolamwini’s spoken word psalm (Section 2.2) gives us a glimpse into what some of the consequences of operating in a top-down, patriarchal manner that does not consider everyone, much less include them at the table.

3.1.2 Building Resistance and Resilience. On the other hand, ideas of resilience and liberation are not new to Christianity or technology. Dr. King’s “Letter from Birmingham Jail” (Section 2.3) evokes the Christian morality in his political resistance by pointing to examples in the Bible of others who have taken extreme measures for justice. He also calls on the concept of “liberation theology,” that demonstrates not only a “living God whose heart is turned with mercy towards those who are oppressed by systemic forces” [20], but also the ability for oppressed people to act towards their own liberation. This liberation theology comes from Black churches in North America [8], like Doctor King’s, as well as from Marxist

thought in Latin America [15]—insight and wisdom from those oppressed [13]. In technology, the concept of “liberation technology” has also included information and communication technologies (ICTs) that help citizens mobilize democracy [10], spread information widely [29], or achieve spiritual, intellectual, and emotional freedom [18].

What then, is our role and responsibility, as designers, builders, and researchers of technology?

First, we must question and critique the practical impacts of the technology we build. While liberation technology shows that social media could be a powerful tool for activists to organize and mobilize, it could also be used as a tool for control or surveillance [23]. In the US, social media users’ private messages have been used to prosecute them for seeking reproductive healthcare and workplace technologies have been used to restrict worker autonomy [34]. Additionally, while the U.S. Surgeon General is heralding the role social media has played in social connection [25], there are reports on how social media negatively affects the mental health of students [4] or marginalized groups like disabled people [17].

By critiquing both the positive and negative societal impacts of technology, we can try to put design and policy limits on the harms that the technology could engender and consider how to design technology that would be more liberatory. Movements like #NoTechForApartheid and #NoTechForICE are coalitions composed of tech workers, activists, and community members that make clear the connections between technology and business decisions made and their use in oppression and state-sanctioned violence. It is imperative for all of us, but especially those of us directly involved in the systems of Silicon Valley, to think critically about the impact we are having on the world—on our neighbors.

Second, we must challenge the power dynamics at play by centering the voices of those most affected—not just the most commercially influential. In 2013, X (formerly Twitter), rolled out a feature to allow users to receive direct messages from any of their followers [31]. While this might have made it easier for brands and other businesses to receive messages from consumers, it also opened the door for increased targeted harassment. Studies have shown that Black women were targeted for harassment on X at “alarming rates” [3]. Hasty feature roll-outs, like this one, are not often made with the lived experience and perspectives of the most targeted users at the forefront—rather, advertiser and commercial interests often take center stage. What would such feature designs and roll-out strategies look like if we changed who was at the center of the users considered? If those users were actually the ones in the room leading the design process? Liberation is about the power, the technology being “taken back by the people” [9]—about centering the agency and self-determination of those most affected by an issue, those at the margins. Design Justice [9] invites us to “center the voices of those who are directly impacted” and Womanist Midrash [14] asks that we “[make] room at the table of discourse for the perspectives of the least privileged among the community and the honored guest of any background.” However, this involves breaking patterns of oppression that have, before this, silenced voices of women, of queer people, of people of color. This could mean having a broader representation in the creators of

technology or including a more diverse set of users when designing and evaluating technology.

Finally, we need to move from charity to solidarity. A common refrain among activists that was collectively developed by an Aboriginal activists group in Queensland is: “If you have come here to help me, you are wasting your time. But if you have come because your liberation is bound up with mine, then let us work together” [26]. However, embedded in the the mindset of technology and technologists-as-savior is a charity mindset. To “save the world” implies that “the world” needs saving—and conversely, that “we” have the power and the answers.

As our gospel reading reminds us (Section 2.4), liberation is not about the privileged simply lending a hand to the poor. Liberation asks us to “listen hard enough so that ‘other people’ become real people” [24]. The implications of recognizing each others’ humanity is massive—recognizing that people are the experts in their own lived experience, with the agency and ideas and creativity to solve the problems they deem most critical in their lives, and with more nuance and rigor than some stranger looking to “fix” them from afar could ever dream of having.

Solidarity is fundamentally relational—we not only recognize each others humanity, but that our lives and our thriving are inextricably related. As Indigenous theology reminds us, we all live on the same planet, and must reckon with the effects of the world we build and the world that has been created for us [33]. We all lose when the technology we build is uncritically used and designed—from inaccessible websites to spyware marketed as safety tools.

3.1.3 Our Invitation. As the root of liturgy, or leitourgia, points to public action, we invite you to not only reflect, but also to act. It is in these actions—challenging and critiquing the practical impacts of technology, no matter how well intentioned, and questioning, challenging, and reshaping the power dynamics at play, and finally, setting aside our presumption and pride to work in solidarity—that we are able to imagine and participate in a world where technology is part and parcel of bringing a new world into being, of transforming society [22].

As we go forth, let us bring a spirit of collective liberation, of aiming to address structural inequities while centering to the lives of those who are most impacted by oppression, by marginalization. Together we can work towards building a world that is not driven by a need for dominance, rather, a world that is able to heal, to restore. Black Liturgist Cole Arthur Riley reminds us that “solidarity is the kind of presence that costs you something”—our comfort, respect from our friends, maybe our livelihoods—and yet, that is the cost of participating in bringing this new world into being.

3.2 *Hymn of the Day

Our hymn of the day is “Sing a New World Into Being” by Mary Louise Bringle in 2006, which places lyrics of celebration on top of the tune of the Hymn to Joy, a piece originally composed by Ludwig van Beethoven in 1824 (Sample Setting).

Sing a new world into being, sound a bold and hopeful theme.
Find a tune for silent yearnings, lend your voice and dare to dream.
Dream a church where all who worship find their lives and loves

belong.

Sing a new world into being, sing as Christ inspires your song.

Sing a new world into being, where each gender class
and race.
Brings its rainbow gifts and colors to God's limitless
embrace.
Where the lines that once divided form instead the
ties that bind.
Sing a new world into being, Risk transforming heart
and mind.

Sing a new world into being, where the homeless find a home.
Where no children ever hunger, but are filled with God's shalom.
Where all people work for justice, where all hate and vengeance
cease.
Sing a new world into being, raise the harmonies of peace.

Sing a new world into being, Join the ancient prophets'
cry.
For a time of health and plenty, when all tears have
been wiped dry.
When compassion flows like waters, pouring balm for
all who grieve.
Sing a new world into being, live the promise you
believe.

4 RESPONSE

4.1 *Confession

In a traditional worship service, the corporal confession is a moment for participants to take a moment to consider not only their personal trespasses but how they have contributed to a structure that is upholding oppression. Ours is Cole Arthur Riley from "Black Liturgies," which integrates spiritual practice with Black emotion, Black literature, and the Black body. We selected this piece for the assembly to say together because of its emphasis on collective responsibility and liberation.

Many of us long for connection and interdependence, but we have become used to enduring the sounds of our own loneliness. We confess that we've become so acquainted with loss and abandonment that we struggle to believe there are those who truly want to be with us. Keep us from pushing them away. Form us to be people of collective responsibility, that we would never become too familiar with hyper-independence but would find ourselves participating in communal restoration and care. Let us find that community which can hold both our lament and rouse our laughter, those who can name their needs and allow space for yours. Let us belong to one another in true mutuality, knowing our burdens and hopes and liberation are mysteriously entwined.

Let us bear it together. We won't get free alone. Amen.

4.2 *Creed

We hope this reflection can build upon the words and ideas scholars have shared before us. Therefore, we present this proclamation of faith as an opportunity to remind us of a few of the frameworks and lessons that are available for us to draw from as we are considering our own roles in liberation.

We believe in using a social-justice orientation for design, in the goals of transformation, recognition, reciprocity, enablement, distribution, and accountability, through commitments to conflict, reflexivity, and personal ethics and politics. [12]

We believe in following the principles of design justice, of using design to sustain, heal, and empower our communities, as well as to seek liberation from exploitative and oppressive systems. [9]

We believe in the tenets of data feminism, of examining and challenging power, exchanging binaries and hierarchies for pluralism, and making emotions, embodiment, and labor visible. [11]

And finally, we believe in CARE when it comes to data governance, In collective benefit, authority to control, responsibility, and ethics When drawing from Indigenous data and Indigenous Knowledge. [5]

4.3 Thanksgiving

Our prayer of thanks is a selection by Rev. Dr. Randy Woodley, a scholar who explores the parallels between Indigenous and Biblical teachings and reconciliation between the two groups. We selected this piece in order to highlight some teachings that extend beyond Euro-Western-centric interpretation of the Bible and emphasize the connection we have to not only each other but to the earth and to the myths that have been woven into its fabric.

Great Mystery, I am humbled that I will never know everything about you, but I am grateful that through the lives of the other I can know more of you. I thank you for those who are like me, but I especially thank you for those who are different than me. I thank you for those who are younger than me and those older than me; for those who have less than me and those who have more than me; for those more physically able than me and those less physically able than me; for those whose skin is of a lighter hue than me and those of a darker hue than me; for those of the opposite sex as me and those of the same sex as me; for those of a different worldview than me and those with a similar worldview as me.

Please help me to discard the old American Myth built on falsehood and justification of racism, sexism, individualism, materialism, greed, and an abuse of

your good earth. These and other lies have kept systems of oppression in place—systems that you hate but I sometimes grow comfortable with. May we together discover a new story for our country where everyone has an equal voice—even those with whom we disagree and even with those who have no voice. **Amen.**

4.4 Offering

An offering is traditionally taken during a service to help support the mission of the church and the care of those in need. In this service, we welcome you to contemplate on what you might offer of yourself to the world as a designer, builder, or researcher of technology. Some things to consider include:

- *What are privileges you have benefited from and strengths you can offer given your identities and positionality?*
- *How have you contributed to conquest or liberation in your work and your life? What does it look like for you to act towards liberation? What changes would you need to make?*
- *What is one thing you see that your own community (i.e., school, workplace, club, congregation) needs? What are ways you could work together towards that?*
- *Who will you bring to your table to imagine of a new world together? What are some of the barriers they may face in coming to the table and what can you do to mitigate them?*
- *How will you continue to reflect on your own position in conquest and liberation? Who will help hold you accountable?*

5 CLOSING

5.1 *Sending Hymn

Our final hymn is a contemporary piece called “Come to the Table” by Common Hymnal in 2018 which celebrates hospitality and the love of strangers (Sample Setting).

Come all proud, come all greedy
Come all liars, come all shamed
Come all wealthy, come receive it
To the table, come today

Come all broken, come all needy
Come all poor, and come all slaves
Come all rulers, come be seated
Come all sinners, come all saints

Come to the table, from near and far
Come from the shadows, come out of the dark
There’s room at the table, we saved you a seat
Come to the banquet, come join in the feast

Every race, every nation
Come all rebels, come all gay
From the fringes, come to Jesus
To a table full of grace
To the table come and stay
Come to the table, come eat and drink

There’s no inner circle, come dine with the king
Recline at the table, come let down your guard
You’re never a stranger, just come as you are

Come be whole, come be loved
Come accepted, come now come

5.2 Benediction

The benediction is a blessing done by the leader on the assembly with final takeaways that they would want to encourage the assembly to take into their life beyond the service.

As we go forth, remind us that “without community, there is no liberation” [21], that we are not alone in our journeys and that we have each other. That we welcome everyone to the table and that together we can have the opportunity to collectively “Sing A New World Into Being”—a world where we not only all belong, but a world where we can all thrive, together. **Amen.**

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

We would like to thank all of those who contributed to this liturgy, including those whose words and ideas are included as excerpts, those who took the time to read and give feedback on this experimental piece, and those who discussed and shaped our experiences in both church and tech culture. We also thank those of you who join us on this journey and look forward to your reflections.

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A INTERACTIVE REFLECTION TOOL

Please use the following guide as a way to reflect on the different sections of the service. Feel free to add any words or images that arise throughout your journey.

Readings & Cross References

Key Points

Notes

Reflection & Application

Prayer
